

Markus Klein

Professor of Human Development and Education Policy | Depute Head (Research)
Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde

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PROFILE

Markus Klein is Professor of Human Development and Education Policy and Depute Head (Research) at the University of Strathclyde. His research examines how educational experiences shape children's life chances, with particular expertise in educational inequalities, school attendance, child development, and education policy. Drawing on longitudinal cohort studies, linked administrative data and advanced quantitative methods, he investigates how family environments, school experiences and institutional contexts influence educational trajectories from childhood into adulthood.

His research has made internationally recognised contributions to understanding the causes and consequences of school attendance, demonstrating how school absence influences educational achievement, post-school destinations and later-life outcomes. More broadly, his work examines how family resources, educational institutions and public policy interact to shape children's cognitive development and educational opportunities across the life course.

His research has attracted competitive funding from the Economic and Social Research Council, the Nuffield Foundation, the British Council and other funders. It has informed education policy and practice through collaborations with governments, international organisations and practitioners, and has been published in leading journals spanning sociology, education and developmental science.

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

2025–	Depute Head (Research), Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde
2024–	Professor of Human Development and Education Policy, Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde
2023–2025	Director of Research, Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde
2022–2024	Reader, Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde
2018–2022	Senior Lecturer, Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde
2016–2018	Lecturer, Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde
2013–2015	Research Associate, Applied Quantitative Methods Network, University of Edinburgh
2008–2013	Research Fellow, Mannheim Centre for European Social Research, University of Mannheim
2005–2007	Research Assistant, Chair of Empirical Social Research, University of Mannheim

RESEARCH PROGRAMME

Markus Klein's research examines how educational experiences shape children's life chances. Combining longitudinal cohort studies, linked administrative data and advanced quantitative methods, I seek to understand how family environments, schools and public policy influence children's cognitive development, educational achievement and later-life outcomes. This work spans four interconnected research programmes.

Educational inequalities across the life course

This programme of research investigates how socioeconomic inequalities emerge, accumulate and can be reduced across childhood, adolescence and early adulthood. It examines how family background, educational institutions and public policy shape educational attainment, social mobility and labour market outcomes, drawing on large-scale longitudinal studies from the United Kingdom and Germany.

School attendance and educational engagement

This programme has established new evidence on the causes, consequences and mechanisms of school attendance and absence. It demonstrates how absences influence educational achievement, post-school transitions and later-life outcomes, identifies when absences are most detrimental, and examines the behavioural and psychosocial pathways through which school attendance contributes to educational inequalities.

Child development and family environments

This research examines how parental education, occupations, family resources and intergenerational processes shape children's cognitive development and educational opportunities. Integrating perspectives from sociology, developmental science and education, it investigates how inequalities emerge during childhood and the mechanisms through which family environments influence children's cognitive and educational development.

Evidence-informed education policy

A central objective of this research is to strengthen education policy and practice through robust empirical evidence. It is undertaken in close collaboration with governments, international organisations, practitioners and education agencies, translating findings from longitudinal and administrative data into evidence that informs educational policy, professional practice and interventions to improve children's life chances.

RESEARCH FUNDING

Principal Investigator

2026	Absent Opportunity? How Protected Characteristics Shape School Attendance in Scotland and England. Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences.	£3,955
2022–2024	Understanding School Attendance, Education, and Labour Market Outcomes. Nuffield Foundation.	£214,755
2018–2023	Social Inequalities in Educational Attainment: An Investigation into the Mediating Role of School Absenteeism. ESRC Secondary Data Analysis Initiative.	£201,551

Co-Investigator and Collaborative Funding

2026	Understanding School Non-Attendance: Cross-Cultural Insights from the United Kingdom and Spain. British Council.	£8,200
2024–2027	Housing inequalities and child wellbeing: ESRC supervisor-led studentship.	£81,000
2023–2026	Family socioeconomic status and school absenteeism: ESRC supervisor-led studentship.	£86,000
2021–2022	Process and Impact Evaluation of the East Lothian Tutoring Initiative. STV Appeal.	£49,138
2017–2019	Nurturing School Ethos to Improve Educational Attainment. Glasgow City Council.	£55,301

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

1. Klein, M. and Kühhirt, M. (2026). Parental education and children's cognitive development: A prospective approach. *Social Forces*, 104(4), 1587–1606.
2. Dräger, J., Klein, M. and Sosu, E. (2025). Does the impact of pupil absences on achievement depend on their timing? *American Educational Research Journal*, 62(5), 872–908.
3. Klein, M. and Sosu, E. (2025). School absences, academic achievement, and adolescents' post-school destinations. *Oxford Review of Education*, 51(3), 339–356.
4. Dräger, J., Klein, M. and Sosu, E. (2024). Trajectories of school absences across compulsory schooling and their impact on children's academic achievement. *PLOS ONE*, 19(8), e0306716.
5. Dräger, J., Klein, M. and Sosu, E. (2024). The long-term consequences of school absences for educational and labour market outcomes. *British Educational Research Journal*, 50(4), 1636–1654.
6. Klein, M. and Sosu, E. (2024). School attendance and academic achievement: Understanding variation across family socioeconomic status. *Sociology of Education*, 97(1), 58–75.
7. Barg, K. and Klein, M. (2024). Maternal occupation-specific skills and children's cognitive development. *Sociology*, 58(1), 118–139.
8. Kühhirt, M., Klein, M. and Demirel, I. (2023). Children's academic achievement and behavior problems at the intersection of gender and family environment. *Socius*, 9.
9. Klein, M., Sosu, E. and Dare, S. (2022). School absenteeism and academic achievement: Does the reason for absence matter? *AERA Open*, 8.
10. Sosu, E., Dare, S., Goodfellow, C. and Klein, M. (2021). Socioeconomic status and school absenteeism: A systematic review and narrative synthesis. *Review of Education*, 9(3), e3291.
11. Klein, M. and Kühhirt, M. (2021). Direct and indirect effects of grandparents' education on grandchildren's cognitive development: The role of parental cognitive ability. *Sociological Science*, 8, 265–284.
12. Klein, M. (2021). Who benefits from attending elite universities? Family background and graduates' career trajectories. *Research in Social Stratification and Mobility*, 72, 100585.

13. Klein, M., Sosu, E. and Dare, S. (2020). Mapping inequalities in school attendance: The relationship between dimensions of socioeconomic status and forms of school absence. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 118, 105432.
14. Kühhirt, M. and Klein, M. (2020). Parental education, television exposure, and children's early cognitive, language and behavioural development. *Social Science Research*, 86, 102391.
15. Jacob, M. and Klein, M. (2019). Social origin, field of study, and graduates' career progression: Does social inequality vary across fields? *British Journal of Sociology*, 70(5), 1850–1873.
16. Klein, M., Barg, K. and Kühhirt, M. (2019). Inequality of educational opportunity in East and West Germany. Convergence or continued differences? *Sociological Science*, 6, 1–26.
17. Kühhirt, M. and Klein, M. (2018). Early maternal employment and children's vocabulary and inductive reasoning ability: A dynamic approach. *Child Development*, 89(2), e91–e106.
18. Iannelli, C., Smyth, E. and Klein, M. (2016). Curriculum differentiation and social inequality in higher education entry in Scotland and Ireland. *British Educational Research Journal*, 42(4), 561–585.
19. Klein, M. (2016). Educational expansion, occupational closure and the relationship between educational attainment and occupational prestige over time. *Sociology*, 50(1), 3–23.
20. Jacob, M., Klein, M. and Iannelli, C. (2015). The impact of social origin on graduates' early occupational destinations: An Anglo-German comparison. *European Sociological Review*, 31(4), 460–476.

CURRENT RESEARCH

- Klein, M. and Barg, K. From spreadsheets to storybooks: How mothers' occupational skills shape activities with children. Conditional acceptance, *Early Childhood Research Quarterly*.
- Dräger, J., Sosu, E. and Klein, M. The mediating role of school absenteeism in the socioeconomic achievement gap. Revise and resubmit.
- Dräger, J., Sosu, E. and Klein, M. How behaviour and motivation mediate the impact of school absences on achievement. Under review.
- MacPherson, L., Fiori, F., Klein, M. and Henderson, M. The rise of private renting among young people in Scotland since the 2000s. Under review.
- Kratz, F. and Klein, M. How do educational equalization strategies affect origin-specific labour market disparities? In preparation.

KEYNOTE AND INVITED LECTURES

2026	Invited talk, University of Glasgow, Bridging Education Research and Policy: Evidence, Practice and Priorities.
2026	Invited talk, University of Strathclyde, Transformative Leadership for Social Justice.
2026	Invited talk, Wolfson College, University of Cambridge.
2026	Invited talk, Department for Education Economics Seminar.
2025	Keynote, Tusla Education Welfare Service Conference, Kilkenny, Ireland.
2025	Invited talk, National Foundation for Educational Research Seminar Series.
2025	Keynote, Annual Scottish Educational Psychology Conference, University of Strathclyde.
2024	Keynote, OECD Peer-learning discussion on monitoring school attendance problems, OECD, Paris.
2024	Keynote, Curriculum Quality and Improvement Service Attendance Conference, South Lanarkshire Council.
2024	Invited talk, Education Endowment Foundation Tuesday Twilight Seminar.
2024	Invited talk, Nuffield Foundation Seminar, London.
2023	Invited talk, All-Party Parliamentary Group for Parental Participation in Education, Westminster.
2023	Invited talk, Scottish Government Education Seminar Series.
2023	Keynote, Attendance Symposium, Forth Valley and West Lothian Regional Improvement Collaborative.
2022	Invited talk, European Association for Population Studies Webinar.

ACADEMIC LEADERSHIP

- Depute Head (Research), Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde.
- Research Excellence Framework (REF) 2029 Lead, Strathclyde Institute of Education, leading the Institute's preparations for the UK's national research assessment exercise
- Director of Research, Strathclyde Institute of Education, University of Strathclyde, 2023–2025.
- Member, Research and Knowledge Exchange Committee, Strathclyde Institute of Education.
- Academic Professional Appointments Panel, Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences.

- Co-Convenor, Quant-HaSS Network, a network supporting quantitative research in the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences.

INTERNATIONAL ESTEEM AND PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Editorial Appointments

- Editorial Board, *Sociology*, 2022–2025.
- Associate Board, *Sociology*, 2016–2022.
- Associate Board, *Work, Employment and Society*, 2014–2019.

Scientific and Advisory Roles

- OECD International Expert on School Attendance.
- Member, Scottish Government Academic Reference Group for the Plan for School Research 2023–2026.
- International Expert, ESRI/Tusla Education Support Service Steering Group on School Attendance.
- Advisory Group, Nuffield Foundation project on "Persistent Absence and Pupil Wellbeing".
- Understanding Attendance Strategic Steering Group, ImpactEd Group.
- Kanter Award Committee for Excellence in Work-Family Research
- Country coordinator for school attendance research in Scotland, International Network for School Attendance.
- Advisory Group, Nuffield Foundation project "Unequal access to higher learning: can the EPQ help with levelling up?" (2023-2025)
- External evaluator, Observatory SOS-Attendance, funded by the European Commission (2023-2025)
- Academic expert on learning loss and socioemotional development for the Data for Children Collaborative with UNICEF (2021-2023)
- Collaborative Community Group (CCG) Equality and Social Justice in the Scottish Government's Independent Review Group (IRG) of Qualifications and Assessments (2022-2023)

Research Assessment and Peer Review

- Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC) Assessor College.
- Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC) Peer Review College.
- SBO (Strategic Basic Research) Steering Committee, FWO, Research Foundation Flanders,
- Generation New Era ESRC Management Board.
- ESRC Early Life Cohort Longitudinal Study / Generation New Era Review Panel.
- Reviewer for Nuffield Foundation, Carnegie Trust, Irish Research Council, Research Ireland, Science Foundation Ireland, Dutch Research Council, German Science Foundation and Swiss National Science Foundation
- Reviewer for journals including *American Sociological Review*, *American Journal of Sociology*, *Social Forces*, *European Sociological Review*, *Demography*, *British Journal of Sociology*, *Sociology*, *Social Science Research*, *Research in Social Stratification and Mobility*, *Child Development*, *AERA Open*, *British Educational Research Journal* and *Oxford Review of Education*.

TEACHING

Teaching expertise spans sociology of education, education policy, social research methods, quantitative methods, globalisation and education, and postgraduate research training. At Strathclyde, I have led and contributed to undergraduate, postgraduate and professional education across the Strathclyde Institute of Education.

- Module leader, Sociology of Education, MSc Education Studies.
- Course leader, MEd Education Studies (2018-2021)
- Module leader, Policy and Politics in Education, BA Primary Education (2016-2019)
- Teaching in social research methods, globalisation and education policy, educational perspectives and policies, and international achievement testing.
- Quantitative methods workshops in Stata, regression methods and multiple imputation for postgraduate students and university staff.

DOCTORAL SUPERVISION AND EXAMINATION

Completed Doctoral Supervision

2025	William Quirke, EdD, Scottish adolescents and urban open spaces.
2023	Scott Orr, PhD, Socioeconomic status and children's behavioural and language development.
2023	Alastair Wilson, PhD, Research design, methods, theory and impact.
2021	Ahmad T. M. Alamri, PhD, Shared decision making in Saudi Arabian schools.

External Examining and Viva Convening

- External PhD examiner, University of Alicante, 2023.
- External PhD examiner, University of Glasgow, 2018.
- Convenor of PhD vivas at the University of Strathclyde.

EDUCATION AND FELLOWSHIPS

2013	PhD in Sociology, University of Mannheim
2008	Diplom in Social Sciences, University of Mannheim
2019–	Fellow of the Higher Education Academy
2018–	Life Course Centre Fellow, ARC Centre of Excellence for Children and Families over the Life Course, University of Queensland

HONOURS AND AWARDS

- Rosabeth Moss Kanter Award for Excellence in Work-Family Research, nominee, 2019.
- British Educational Research Journal Editor's Choice Award, commended, 2017.
- British Sociological Association Early Career Award, 2015.
- QMSS2 Conference Award, University of Bamberg, 2010.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- International Sociological Association Research Committee 28 on Social Stratification and Social Mobility.
- Society for Longitudinal and Lifecourse Studies.
- European Association for Population Studies, Working Group on Child and Adolescent Development.
- International Network for School Attendance.